CHAPTER ONE:
HALL OF ARMOR

"I am Iron Man." With those words at the close of the first Iron Man film, the cinematic super hero changed forever. The movie had already revolutionized the genre, both conceptually—a flawed, adult hero coming to a harsh realization about the life he was leading—tonally—a heady mix of humor, pathos, and real-world politics—and technically—a seamless mix of the physical and the digital.

But the move to have Tony Stark, as brilliantly portrayed by Robert Downey Jr., reveal his "secret identity" to the world—with characteristic bravado—created yet another revolution. Not only was this unprecedented for a super hero movie, and not only did it bring the film even more strongly in line with the comic book series upon which it was based…but for Tony, it made him the world's most visible target.

"It's about six months later that we pick up with Tony Stark, at the start of Iron Man 2," explains producer Kevin Feige. "He's been Iron Man for six months. He's gone on adventures around the world, he's intervened in all sorts of political crises, and he's made quite a name for himself. If he was the most famous man in America in the first movie, he's the most famous man in the world in this movie."

That kind of fame mirrors the real-world phenomenon of the Iron Man franchise. "It's hard to believe now, but two years ago not everybody knew Iron Man," says Feige. "The success of Iron Man, globally, was well over $500 million. It was a phenomenon of the year, and for us at Marvel—everybody knows Iron Man now."

And with that knowledge comes high expectations. The cast and crew of Iron Man 2 were up for the challenge. Returning figures both behind and in front of the camera welcomed the new faces, and production began mere months after the first film premiered. Jon Favreau was back in the director's chair, with his trusted team of conceptual artists and visual effects experts going to work. "Part of the difficulty of these super hero movies is that everything has been done," Favreau realized. "So how do you make it different, not only from our first film, but from what everybody else is doing?"

